

that actually was stale public news. I'd gotten in just as the takeover people were getting out. Sitting there with Orton, I felt as if I'd walked through a jungle, happened upon a magnificent ancient ruin, and run back to trumpet my discovery—only to be told I'd seen the back side of Machu Picchu.

As I write this, my Bally options are still alive. They don't expire for two months, so anything could happen. The stock is selling for \$20. If it goes to \$40, I'll double my money and come home a winner. If it doesn't, I've lost most of the \$14,000 I put in over the months of this journey, give or take a few hundred, and not including all the airplane fares, taxis, meals, and other expenses.

I returned home from New York, ready to admit I'd run out of good ideas, not to mention money. I'd hoped to learn something about the bond market over a dinner with Ms. Jenrette, the expert from Bridgewater Securities, but when I phoned that office they told me Ms. Jenrette had gone away and had left no forwarding address. Having lost confidence in forecasters, except for Mr. Crawford; having learned too much to trust most stockbrokers; having followed the stream of analysts, market advisors, portfolio managers and floor traders, I could only marvel at anybody who succeeds on Wall Street. To make money here, you'd either have to know a lot more or a lot less than I do.

I ought to mention that my wife's portfolio at Drexel Burnham Lambert, under the guidance of Richard Bermont, had continued to do well in the months I'd been off investing for my own account. Her gains made up for most of my apparent loss. In fact, I figured that the two of us together had just about broken even for the year, which is one of the reasons I'm still allowed to live at home.

This brings me back to my good old savings account and Centrust S&L. Looking back on it, I would have collected \$1,200 in interest by leaving my entire stake alone in the bank from the beginning. This isn't too exciting in itself, but added to the funds I wouldn't have squandered, I'd be left with a \$15,200 windfall, the kind of profit an average investor can only dream about. If you've ever felt stupid for not having participated in a great bull market, remember my example, and also Useful Tip Number 24: